

Homeopathy: what does the "best" evidence tell us?

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OBJECTIVE: To evaluate the evidence for and against the effectiveness of homeopathy. DATA SOURCES: The Cochrane Database of Systematic Reviews (generally considered to be the most reliable source of evidence) was searched in January 2010. STUDY SELECTION: Cochrane reviews with the term "homeopathy" in the title, abstract or keywords were considered. Protocols of reviews were excluded. Six articles met the inclusion criteria. DATA EXTRACTION: Each of the six reviews was examined for specific subject matter; number of clinical trials reviewed; total number of patients involved; and authors' conclusions. The reviews covered the following conditions: cancer, attention-deficit hyperactivity disorder, asthma, dementia, influenza and induction of labour. DATA SYNTHESIS: The findings of the reviews were discussed narratively (the reviews' clinical and statistical heterogeneity precluded meta-analysis). CONCLUSIONS: The findings of currently available Cochrane reviews of studies of homeopathy do not show that homeopathic medicines have effects beyond placebo.